

Q What equipment will we need for washing our baby?

In the first few weeks of your baby's life, you will probably be combining regular bathing with sponge bathing (see p.284), where you clean your baby without immersing her in a tub of water.

There's no need to bathe your newborn every day, unless she loves having a bath and finds it soothing or enjoyable; she'll only need a bath two or three times a week on average. Carefully washing your baby's face, neck, hands, and bottom—known as sponge

bathing—requires very little equipment, but does need to be done thoroughly every day that your baby doesn't have a bath. Whichever you do, get everything ready beforehand and make sure that the room and the water are warm.

SPONGE BATHING

You will need only basic equipment:

» **Cotton balls.** Use a fresh piece for separate areas, including around the ears and eyes.

» **Two bowls of water,** one for each end of the body to avoid cross infection.



WATER BOWL

BATHING

For bathing your baby you will need the following:

» **Baby bath,** a sink, or a big bathtub. The advantage of a baby bath is that you can use it in any room. If your baby seems to dislike the water, try bathing together and soothing her as you do.

» **Nonslip mat** only if you are planning to use a big bathtub.

» **Bath thermometer** can be used to check the temperature of the water is 95–100° F (35–38° C), or you can test the bath temperature with your elbow, checking that it is warm, but not hot.

» **A combined mild baby shampoo and bath product** used sparingly, although plain water is usually better for cleaning your baby at first.

» **Soft washcloths or a sponge**

» **2–3 hooded baby towels,** to wrap your baby up in after bathing and stop her from losing heat through her head.

» **Olive oil or baby oil,** for rubbing into your baby's towel-dried skin.



Bath time This is a great opportunity to play with your baby so have everything you need prepared around you.

Q I heard that you should wash baby clothes before they are worn. Is that really necessary?

Yes, it's a good idea to wash your baby's clothes before she first wears them. This simple precaution ensures that any residues of substances from the manufacturing process that could irritate your baby's sensitive skin are removed. Use nonbiological detergents to wash all your baby's clothes, bedding, and burp cloths, since these detergents don't contain enzymes, which can also prove an irritant.

Q Is it a good idea to buy a room thermometer? Where should we put it?

It is a good idea—making sure the room your baby sleeps in is the right temperature reduces the risk of sudden infant death syndrome (SIDS). The ideal room temperature for a baby is around 64° F (18° C). If you want to ensure your baby doesn't get too hot or cold, you may want to have several thermometers around the house. Options range from affordable strip thermometers stuck to laminated board to smart digital thermometers. Remember though that if the room temperature is right, your baby won't need more than a sleep sack.

Q How do I choose a good diaper bag and what should I put in it?

You can choose a diaper bag with a foldaway changing mat, although you don't have to buy a purpose-made diaper bag; you can use a bag of your choice and buy a separate fold-up changing mat. Have the following items ready as a diaper-changing kit in the bag for when you're away from the house:

» **A few disposable diapers** and disposal bags.

» **Travel-sized package** of unperfumed baby wipes (try to use sparingly, since they can be harsh on your newborn's delicate skin).

» **A small container** or travel-sized container of diaper cream to prevent or ease diaper rash.

» **Spare clothes** for your baby and for you. When you use any of these items to change your baby while you are out, remember to restock the supplies when you get home so the bag is all ready for your next trip out.